

How CSR impact meaning of work and dysfunctional customer behavior

Work and
dysfunctional
customer
behavior

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to investigate how frontline service employees' (FSEs) perceptions of corporate social responsibility (CSR) can enhance meaningful work perceptions as well as help alleviate FSEs' perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior.

Design/methodology/approach – The conceptual model is empirically examined through a survey of 306 FSEs of a large insurance company in South Korea and tested via structural equation modeling.

Findings – The results indicate that FSEs' perceptions of CSR are negatively related to their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer conduct, which in turn is shown to be directly linked to emotional exhaustion. FSEs' CSR perceptions strengthen their view that they are performing meaningful work (i.e. perceived task significance), which in turn strengthens their job satisfaction.

Practical implications – CSR has a preventive effect on workplace stress reduction, as FSE perceptions of CSR may help them cope with the emotional fatigue of dealing with dysfunctional customer behavior. CSR also provides a needs fulfillment effect, as FSEs' perceptions of CSR foster perceived task significance and helps reduce their emotional exhaustion from work.

Originality/value – This is the first study to examine the potential impact of CSR within the context of FSEs' boundary spanning emotional labor.

Keywords Corporate social responsibility, Emotional exhaustion, Dysfunctional customer behavior

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

In 1983, Hochschild first introduced the concept of emotional labor which requires frontline service employees (FSEs) to manage their own emotions while producing organizationally desired emotions in order to deliver quality service. FSEs often interact with demanding, unfriendly and sometimes even abrasive customers, yet they are expected to remain courteous and professional throughout each service encounter (Geng *et al.*, 2018; McColl-Kennedy *et al.*, 2009). As boundary spanners, FSEs serve as bridges between the service firm and its customers, which can often contribute to negative emotions and emotional exhaustion, which in turn negatively impacts their job performance (Dallimore *et al.*, 2007; Singh *et al.*, 1994). To overcome verbal dysfunctional customer behaviors, FSEs are encouraged to employ practical coping tactics to alleviate the stress they experience when customers behave in deviant fashions (Echeverri *et al.*, 2012; Reynolds and Harris, 2006). Furthermore, FSEs expect that their organizations will be fair and provide proper managerial interventions when dealing with verbally dysfunctional customer behavior (Gong *et al.*, 2014).



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In this study, we expand the relevant service marketing literature by investigating the potential impact of corporate social responsibility (CSR) as a mechanism to improve frontline customer service work and help alleviate the negative effects of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior perceptions of FSEs. CSR has emerged as one of the most important imperatives for contemporary business practices. A survey by Cone (2016) found that 74 percent of workers in the USA agreed that their job is more fulfilling when they are provided opportunities to make a positive impact on social and environmental issues. CSR is broadly defined as a company's activities and status relative to its societal obligations (Brown and Dacin, 1997). Delivered in an array of formats, CSR initiatives typically focus on corporate brands and their societal relationships with external constituencies, including customers, not-for-profit organizations and local communities (Ellen *et al.*, 2006). While it is well established in the literature that CSR can effectively enhance job performance of frontline employees (e.g. Korschun *et al.*, 2014; Larson *et al.*, 2008), far less is known about the potential value of CSR in relationship to workers who routinely expend emotional labor in their roles as FSEs. In particular, there is a lack of research on how CSR perceptions held by employees may contribute to reducing the emotional duress associated when managing verbal dysfunctional customer behaviors in a frontline services setting.

In an effort to fill this void, we examine how the presence of strong CSR perceptions held by FSEs weaken the extent to which they experience emotional exhaustion suffered from dealing from verbal dysfunctional customer conduct. Moreover, we investigate how CSR perceptions held by FSEs may strengthen their view that they are performing meaningful service (i.e. perceived task significance) and its consequential positive impact on strengthening job satisfaction. We begin with a review of relevant literature to gain a deeper understanding of how FSEs' CSR perceptions may help shape their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior, emotional exhaustion and task significance. This is followed by a description of the research methodology we used to empirically test the hypothesized relationships of our conceptual model. Finally, we discuss the key findings and their managerial implications, and offer future research opportunities to build on this research study.

Conceptual framework and hypotheses development

The proposed conceptual model is depicted in Figure 1. We anticipate that FSEs' strong CSR perceptions of their service firm employer are negatively related to their verbal dysfunctional customer behavior perceptions. FSEs' perceived verbal dysfunctional customer behavior is also expected to mediate the linkage between FSEs' CSR perceptions and emotional exhaustion. Furthermore, we anticipate that FSEs' strong CSR perceptions directly affect the positive task significance of their work, which sequentially leads to job satisfaction. We also expect perceived task significance will have a negative relationship with emotional exhaustion. Next, we develop the constructs of our model and present supporting literature for their respective posited relationships.

FSEs' perceptions of CSR and verbal dysfunctional customer behavior

Dysfunctional customer behavior is analogous to problem customers (Bitner *et al.*, 1994), consumer misbehavior (Fullerton and Punj, 2004), deviant customer behavior (Moschis and Cox, 1989) and customer aggression (Ben-Zur and Yagil, 2005). A common thread among all these terms is the notion that some customers violate generally accepted standards of conduct and display behavior which is commonly viewed as disreputable by organizations, employees and other customers (Harris and Reynolds, 2003). In this study, we consider the perceptions of employees who are at the frontline, interacting with customers who violate norms through various verbal dysfunctional behaviors, such as unwarranted complaining

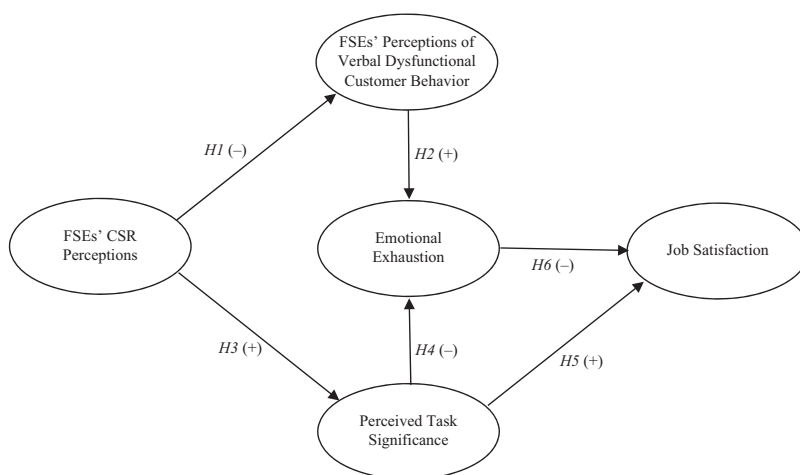


Figure 1.
Conceptual model

behavior, voiced aggression, anger and even rage (Dallimore *et al.*, 2007; Harris, 2013; Huang and Miao, 2016; Van Jaarsveld *et al.*, 2010).

Our focus is on FSEs' perceptions of their company's externally focused CSR activities and the important role that CSR can play in reducing their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior. FSEs' perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior describe their views about various forms of voiced customer sentiments which are regarded to violate generally accepted norms with such attitudes generally viewed to be overly demanding and sometimes dishonest (McColl-Kennedy *et al.*, 2009). To the best of our knowledge, the negative relationship between FSEs' CSR perceptions and their verbal dysfunctional customer behavior perceptions has not been examined prior to this study.

Previous studies have focused on employees' perceptions to understand the psychological mechanisms that link CSR activities and desirable individual employee characteristics, including job satisfaction, employee commitment and outstanding work performance (e.g. De Roeck and Maon, 2016; Korschun *et al.*, 2014; Lee *et al.*, 2013). Employee perceptions of CSR, depending on the type of beneficiaries (De Roeck and Maon, 2016), can be broadly categorized as evaluations of internal initiatives (e.g. policies aimed at improving working conditions, education programs, etc.) and external initiatives (e.g. involvement with charitable causes, funding nonprofit organizations, providing support for the community, etc.).

From a theoretical perspective, Ashforth and Humphrey (1993) linked the concept of emotional labor to social identity theory. Social identity theory helps explain people's conduct within groups (Hogg and Abrams, 1988). Social identity theory illuminates how shared organizational activities can be used to signal group identity and express group belonging (Hogg and Abrams, 1988; Tajfel and Turner, 1986). High social identity positively contributes to employees' self-perceived status and fosters their sense of self in society (Gond *et al.*, 2010). Employees generally identify with a company when they believe that the company possesses admirable traits that reflect their self-concept (Kim *et al.*, 2010). Employees feel better about themselves when they perceive that they are part of an organization that practices good corporate citizenship (Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2008). Hence, employees who identify strongly with their employer view the company's traits and activities as their own (Bhattacharya and Sen, 2003).

A central tenet of CSR relates to social identity theory. CSR makes a company more appealing for employees and their identification with the company (Lin, 2010). CSR has been

demonstrated to affect employee compassion in the workplace. Moon *et al.* (2014) found that employee's perceptions of CSR were linked to compassion through organizational justice. Zoghbi-Manrique-de-Lara and Guerra-Baez (2016) also explored the influence of ethical climate on employee compassion and empirically demonstrated that a benevolent CSR climate is positively related with kindness in the context of hotel FSEs. Moreover, FSEs exhibiting kindness tend to be more patient when dealing with deviant customers and have a stronger desire to alleviate their distress (Zoghbi-Manrique-de-Lara and Guerra-Baez, 2016).

CSR can play an important role in strengthening FSEs' level of customer orientation (Korschun *et al.*, 2014), which has been shown to decrease perceptions of customer phone rage among FSEs working in call centers (Harris, 2013). Employees can evaluate their organizational support in accordance with their perceptions about the way their organization treats external groups (Gong *et al.*, 2014). When employees perceive their company as socially responsible, they believe that their company is just and cares about their employees' welfare (Cheng *et al.*, 2013; Rupp, 2011). Thus, we anticipate that FSEs' perceived social responsibility of their employer will have a direct and negative effect on their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior:

H1. FSEs' CSR perceptions are negatively related to their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior.

FSEs' dysfunctional customer behavior perceptions and emotional exhaustion

Emotional labor is related to employee burnout and specifically to emotional exhaustion (Abraham, 1998; Brotheridge and Lee, 2002). Emotional exhaustion refers to a state of depleted energy caused by excessive emotional demands (Saxton *et al.*, 1991). Previous research has explored the relationship between dysfunctional customer behavior and FSEs' boundary spanning emotional exhaustion (Karatepe *et al.*, 2009a, b; Singh *et al.*, 1994; Van Jaarsveld *et al.*, 2010). FSEs often develop their own coping strategies in response to overly demanding and rude customers (Echeverri *et al.*, 2012; Rupp *et al.*, 2006; Yagil and Schultz, 2017). Even then, FSEs may still struggle to successfully cope with dysfunctional customer behavior. Van Jaarsveld *et al.* (2010) found that customer incivility toward employees is linked to emotional exhaustion resulting from their job demands. Furthermore, dealing with verbally dysfunctional customers leads to a heightened sense of loss of control by employees when confronted by customers' incivility, voiced aggression and other disruptive behaviors (Hockey, 1993).

FSEs' emotional exhaustion can be directly affected by their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior (Singh *et al.*, 1994). Huang and Miao (2016) documented the emotional plight of hotel and restaurant workers when they were expected to meet unreasonable demands from deviant customers, contributing to role conflict. FSEs are more susceptible to work overload because they spending additional time working to resolve dysfunctional customer demands with their supervisors and other coworkers (Singh *et al.*, 1994). Indeed, in a hotel setting, Karatepe *et al.* (2009b) found that FSEs' perceptions of customer's aggression were directly linked to emotional exhaustion. In a mobile phone service provider study, Baranik *et al.* (2017) demonstrated that FSEs' perceptions of customer mistreatment were related to emotional exhaustion. Hence the following hypothesis is proposed:

H2. FSE's perceived verbal dysfunctional customer behavior is positively related to their emotional exhaustion.

FSEs' CSR perceptions and task significance

Researchers have demonstrated how CSR can be instrumental in fulfilling psychological needs of employees (e.g. Bauman and Skitka, 2012; Bhattacharya *et al.*, 2008; Gong *et al.*, 2014;

Rosso *et al.*, 2010; Rupp *et al.*, 2006). Employees may be able to feel a greater sense of meaningful life existence at work when they believe that their employer contributes to improvements in other people's lives through CSR activities (Bauman and Skitka, 2012). Raub and Blunschi (2014) demonstrate how perceived task significance plays a mediating role between CSR and job satisfaction among FSEs in a hotel chain setting. Task significance refers to the judgments that one's job influences the lives or work of others (Morgeson and Humphrey, 2006). Studies on job design show that employees judge their jobs highly in task significance when they experience their work as more meaningful (Morgeson and Humphrey, 2006; Raub and Blunschi, 2014). Based on the highlighted literature, we anticipate that FSEs' perceived CSR of their employer will have a direct and positive effect on their perceptions of task significance:

H3. FSEs' CSR perceptions are positively related to their perceived task significance.

Perceived task significance and emotional exhaustion

Scholars have argued that to the extent that employees are able to satisfy their psychological needs (e.g. meaningful work) through their company's CSR activities, employees may experience reduced emotional exhaustion on the job (Bauman and Skitka, 2012; Raub and Blunschi, 2014). Thus, we anticipate that CSR has an impact on FSEs' emotional exhaustion through perceived task significance, as a need fulfillment effect. Intrinsically motivated employees are able to cope psychologically with stressful stimuli (Low *et al.*, 2001). Intrinsic motivation is closely related with basic need satisfaction, which is the motivational process capturing employees' psychological energy (Van den Broeck *et al.*, 2008).

Previous studies demonstrate that work motivation allows employees to cope with emotional exhaustion by biasing perceptions of stressful stimuli (Karatepe and Tekinkus, 2006; Low *et al.*, 2001). Similarly, motivated employees expend additional time and energy to complete their assigned tasks (Zhang and Bartol, 2010). FSEs who perceive their work as meaningful are better positioned to deal with demanding customers, and therefore less likely to suffer from emotional exhaustion (Raub and Blunschi, 2014; Van Jaarsveld *et al.*, 2010). Therefore, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H4. FSEs' perceived task significance has a negative relationship with their emotional exhaustion.

Perceived task significance and job satisfaction

The creation of customer oriented boundary-spanning behaviors (e.g. external representation, internal influence, service delivery) depends on the level of job satisfaction (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003). Job satisfaction refers to "the emotional affective response to a job or specific aspects of a job" (Spector, 1985, p. 695). Job characteristics have long been understood as antecedents of positive work outcomes (e.g. Hackman and Oldham, 1975). Employees who perceive their work as significant and valuable report higher levels of job satisfaction (Glavas and Kelley, 2014; Morgeson and Humphrey, 2006; Raub and Blunschi, 2014). Furthermore, Seligman (2002) suggested that living a meaningful life provides the most lasting form of happiness. In this sense, employees can live a meaningful life through meaningful work and job satisfaction. In other words, prosocial elements of work are meaningful because they bring individuals into harmony with others (Rosso *et al.*, 2010). In line with the examined management literature, we anticipate that FSEs' perceived task significance of their work will be positively related to their job satisfaction:

H5. FSEs' perceived task significance has a positive relationship with their job satisfaction.

Emotional exhaustion and job satisfaction

High levels of employee emotional exhaustion lead to low job performance (Hur *et al.*, 2015). Specifically, emotional exhaustion is known to result in numerous negative effects on employee performance, such as job dissatisfaction and higher employee turnover (Babakus *et al.*, 2009; Bakker *et al.*, 2004; Lu and Gursay, 2016). Given that job satisfaction is an affective-based overall evaluation of employees' job situation and experience (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003), emotional exhaustion is anticipated to be negatively related to job satisfaction (Singh *et al.*, 1994). Employees suffering from emotional exhaustion are in a state of depleted emotional resources (Singh *et al.*, 1994) or psychological withdrawal in the form of reduced job satisfaction (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003). Karatepe *et al.* (2009b) examined the influence of customers' verbal aggression on hotel employees' emotional exhaustion, which in turn negatively impacted their job satisfaction. Hence, in the light of extant research, it is logical to anticipate a negative relationship between emotional exhaustion of FSEs and their job satisfaction:

H6. Emotional exhaustion of FSEs has a negative relationship on their job satisfaction.

Moderating variables

Given the scarcity of research that investigate the linkages between CSR and boundary spanning emotional labor, this study also examines the potential impact of individual variables on the posited relationships of this study. More specifically, previous research suggests that gender, age, job position and years of work experience with current employer may affect our model's results. Valentine and Fleischman (2008) found that CSR, gender and age were positively related to job satisfaction. In another study, members of the Millennial generation were shown to hold stronger normative beliefs regarding ethical consumerism compared with older adults, with women displaying more awareness and concern for supporting CSR initiatives than men (Bucic *et al.*, 2012). Job characteristics also may impact the posited model. For example, higher demanding jobs often lead to emotional exhaustion (Alarcon, 2011). Thus, managers would be expected to be associated with higher levels of perceived task significance, emotional exhaustion and job satisfaction than their non-manager counterparts.

Research method

To test the posited relationships of our conceptual model, we conducted a survey of FSEs with the support of one of the largest property and casualty insurance companies in South Korea. The survey data were provided by customer service representatives and their supervisors who work in the participating insurance company's claims department. Serving individual customers with property and casualty insurance coverage, the primary duty of the sampled customer service representatives and their supervisors was to assist customers when filing a claim, such as serving those customers who experienced a car accident. In many instances, these FSEs were interacting with customers under very stressful circumstances. In our preliminary discussions with employees of the insurance company, we learned that it was common for customers to insist on receiving greater compensation than allowed under the terms and conditions of their insurance policies.

The data collection was done via web-based questionnaires. Included with the link to the online survey was an email of instructions from a human resource manager of the insurance company. The survey was sent to all eligible customer service representatives and their supervisors and direct managers who worked in the auto insurance division of the insurance company. The link to the survey was left open for two weeks in July 2015. Out of 348 subjects approached, a total of 328 responses were collected. Elimination of 22 incomplete answers resulted in 306 valid responses (a valid response rate of 87.9 percent).

The final sample was closely divided between staff employees (51.5 percent) and their supervisors/direct managers (48.7 percent). In terms of work experience with the respondent's current employer, 53.6 percent had worked for the insurance company for less than three years. Slightly more than half (52.3 percent) of the respondents were female. Almost all respondents were below the age of 40, with 49.7 percent ranging between 20 and 29-years old and 48 percent between 30 and 39-years old.

Measurement and scale items

Understanding the conceptual model's posited relationships required measurement of FSEs' perceptions of their employer and customers. Existing scales from the literature were used to measure the constructs of interest with slight modifications to fit the study context. All five constructs were operationalized using multi-item measures and used five-point Likert type scales, anchored by 1 = strongly disagree and 5 = strongly agree.

A seven-item scale measuring FSEs' CSR perceptions was adapted from Berens *et al.* (2005), Lichtenstein *et al.* (2004) and Wagner *et al.* (2009). Each of the selected CSR items gauges the respondent's perceptions about how their company serves nonprofit organizations, their community, as well as societal and environmental issues. Five items of FSEs' perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior were adapted from Wang *et al.* (2011), McColl-Kennedy *et al.* (2009) and Karatepe *et al.* (2009a) and modified to match the context of the study and its conceptualization of various forms of customer misconduct because they violate generally accepted norms. The five-item perceived task significance scale was adapted from Grant (2008) and Morgeson and Humphrey (2006) to focus on whether FSEs view their work as having a significant impact on the lives of others. Three items were adapted from Maslach and Jackson's (1981) burnout scale to assess FSEs' perceptions of emotional exhaustion. Finally, in order to capture job satisfaction, three measurement items from Homburg and Stock (2004) were adopted to evaluate overall job satisfaction rather than specific dimensions of job satisfaction. The scale items are listed in the Appendix.

Data analysis, reliability and validity

The hypothesized relationships were tested using the two-step structural equation modeling (SEM) procedure advocated by Anderson and Gerbing (1988). This method of measurement and testing relationships allowed for rigorous testing of measurement reliability and validity of the data before subjecting the structural model to tests of fit. A covariance matrix was created and subjected to confirmatory factor analysis. Despite the $p < 0.01$ significance of the χ^2 ($\chi^2_{(215)} = 421.22$), the measurement model demonstrated good fit of the data based upon a variety of other absolute and incremental fit measures, including normed fit index (NFI) = 0.94, comparative fit index (CFI) = 0.97, goodness of fit index (GFI) = 0.89 and root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) = 0.056. The factor-loading scores confirm that all measures exhibit convergent validity (see Table I). Moreover, the Pearson correlations among the measures confirm that all measures were distinct from each other, thus resulting in sufficient evidence of divergent validity (see Table II).

The construct measures yielded sound reliability and validity properties (Table I). All measures exhibit a Cronbach's α of 0.89 or higher and a composite reliability exceeding 0.90, suggesting a satisfactory level of reliability (Bagozzi and Yi, 1988). Evidence of discriminant validity was displayed via average variance extracted ranging from 0.64 to 0.82, with each measure exceeding the 0.50 benchmark (Bagozzi and Yi, 1988). To examine for common method bias, a confirmatory factor analysis was estimated in which all indicators included in the model were restricted to load on a single factor (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003). The fit indices obtained from this test showed a poor fit (e.g. NFI = 0.61; GFI = 0.48; RMSEA = 0.192), indicating that common method bias did not pose a problem (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003).

Table I.
Reliability and
validity assessment
of the construct
measures

Construct	Item	Standard factor loading	<i>t</i> -value	<i>p</i> -value	Cronbach's α	CR	AVE
FSEs' CSR perceptions	CSR1	0.919					
	CSR2	0.915	27.621	***			
	CSR3	0.924	28.529	***			
	CSR4	0.921	28.244	***			
	CSR5	0.919	28.064	***			
	CSR6	0.899	26.290	***			
	CSR7	0.846	22.383	***	0.97	0.97	0.822
FSE's perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior	DCB1	0.867					
	DCB2	0.866	19.520	***			
	DCB3	0.862	19.374	***	0.90	0.90	0.645
	DCB4	0.744	15.304	***			
	DCB5	0.654	12.691	***			
Perceived task significance	TS1	0.823					
	TS2	0.851	17.159	***			
	TS3	0.854	24.808	***	0.93	0.92	0.697
	TS4	0.842	16.733	***			
	TS5	0.802	15.598	***			
Emotional exhaustion	EE1	0.849			0.90	0.90	0.754
	EE2	0.887	19.223	***			
	EE3	0.869	18.736	***			
Job satisfaction	JS1	0.855					
	JS2	0.895	19.351	***	0.89	0.90	0.741
	JS3	0.831	17.617	***			

Notes: χ^2 (df = 215) = 421.22; p = 0.000; χ^2 /df = 1.959; GFI = 0.89; NFI = 0.94; CFI = 0.97; RMSEA = 0.056.
*** p < 0.001

Table II.
Discriminant validity
of the construct
measures

	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5
1. FSEs' CSR perceptions	3.51	0.84	(0.91)				
2. FSEs' perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior	3.55	0.79	−0.14	(0.80)			
3. Perceived task significance	3.87	0.76	0.64	0.03	(0.84)		
4. Emotional exhaustion	3.40	0.93	−0.20	0.57	−0.20	(0.87)	
5. Job satisfaction	3.37	0.74	0.42	−0.23	0.57	−0.53	(0.86)

Note: The diagonal elements are the square roots of average of variance extracted and the lower left triangle elements are the Pearson correlations

Results

Overall fit statistics suggested a good fit between the hypothesized model and the observed data. The proposed structural model exhibited acceptable levels of fit with $\chi^2_{(218)} = 393.79$, NFI = 0.94, CFI = 0.97, GFI = 0.90, and RMSEA = 0.051. Given the satisfactory fit of the structural model, the standardized coefficients are inspected. Table III lists the hypothesized test results.

As predicted in *H1*, the posited negative relationship between FSEs' perceptions of CSR and their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior of the tested context is significant ($\gamma = -0.14$, $t = -2.25$, $p < 0.05$). As well, as predicted in *H2*, FSEs' perceived verbal dysfunctional customer behavior is found to be positively and directly related to their emotional exhaustion ($\beta = 0.56$, $t = 9.61$, $p < 0.001$). As predicted in *H3*, the positive relationship between FSEs' CSR perceptions and their perceived task significance is supported ($\gamma = 0.65$, $t = 11.44$, $p < 0.001$). The predicted negative relationship between

Table III.
Hypothesis test
results

	Standardized estimate	SE	t-value
<i>H1</i> : FSEs' CSR perceptions → FSE's perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior	-0.14	0.056	-2.25*
<i>H2</i> : FSE's perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior → emotional exhaustion	0.56	0.064	9.61***
<i>H3</i> : FSEs' CSR perceptions → perceived task significance	0.65	0.050	11.44***
<i>H4</i> : perceived task significance → emotional exhaustion	-0.21	0.062	-3.92***
<i>H5</i> : perceived task significance → job satisfaction	0.48	0.050	8.74***
<i>H6</i> : emotional exhaustion → job satisfaction	-0.42	0.042	-7.92***
Notes: χ^2 (df = 218) = 393.79; p = 0.000; χ^2 /df = 1.806; GFI = 0.90; NFI = 0.94; CFI = 0.97; RMSEA = 0.051. * p < 0.05; *** p < 0.001			

FSEs' perceived task significance and their emotional exhaustion (*H4*) is shown to be significant ($\beta = -0.21$, $t = 3.92$, $p < 0.001$). With respect to *H5*, the results reveal a significant and positive relationship between FSEs' perceived task significance and their job satisfaction ($\beta = 0.48$, $t = 8.74$, $p < 0.001$). Finally, the hypothesized negative relationship between FSEs' emotional exhaustion and their job satisfaction (*H6*) is sustained ($\beta = -0.42$, $t = -7.92$, $p < 0.001$).

Following the procedures prescribed by Joreskog and Sorbom (2006), the SEM multi-group comparison reveals that gender positively moderated *H2*'s relationship between FSEs' perceived verbal dysfunctional customer behavior and their emotional exhaustion ($p = 0.02$). More specifically, women were significantly more likely to experience emotional exhaustion than men as a result of their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior. None of the other five hypotheses of the model were impacted by gender. Moreover, age was not shown to have a significant moderating impact on any of the six hypothesized paths of the conceptual model.

The SEM multi-group analysis also reveals marginal support for the respective moderation effects of respondent's job position (staff vs their supervisors/direct managers; $p = 0.057$) and years of work experience with their employer (< 3 years vs 3+ years; $p = 0.052$) toward intensifying the negative relationship between FSEs' perceived task significance and their emotional exhaustion (*H4*). To be more precise, supervisors and direct managers were more likely to experience emotional exhaustion than their staff members as a result of perceived task significance. Similarly, FSEs with three or more years of work tenure were more apt to experience emotional exhaustion (than those FSEs reporting less than three years of experience) as a consequence of perceived task significance. Neither years of work experience nor job position held by the respondents was shown to have a significant moderating impact on any of the remaining five paths of our model.

In summary, the SEM multi-group results show weak empirical evidence of moderation effects among the examined demographic and employee characteristics. Only 3 of the 24 examined moderation effects were found to be statistically significant, with only one moderation effect at the $p < 0.05$ level.

Discussion

The manners in which CSR activities are associated with the job performance of FSEs remain relatively unexplored (Korschun *et al.*, 2014). This study suggests that FSEs' perceptions of CSR are strategically valuable, especially as a preventive mechanism to defend against FSEs' emotional exhaustion. In part based on social identity theory (Hogg and Abrams, 1988; Tajfel and Turner, 1986), an individual's positive associations of

being employed by a socially responsible organization are shown to have a negative relationship with their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior. Further, the findings demonstrate how FSEs' CSR perceptions can indirectly weaken the emotional exhaustion effects that may result from dealing with dysfunctional customer demands. This is the first study to examine the potential contribution of CSR perceptions within the context of FSEs' boundary spanning emotional labor. CSR can play an instrumental role in indirectly impacting the emotional exhaustion suffered by FSEs, by simultaneously strengthening the meaning of their work and weakening their perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior.

The results indicate that FSEs' perceptions of CSR negatively impact their perceptions of demanding, unfriendly and sometimes even abrasive customer conduct. The implications of lowering verbal dysfunctional behavior perceptions of FSEs are clearly seen in the other paths of our model. Specifically, FSEs who are adversely affected by their perceptions of dysfunctional customer demands tend to become emotionally exhausted, which in turn negatively influences their job satisfaction. On the other hand, the results show that CSR perceptions held by FSEs may strengthen their view that they are performing meaningful work (i.e. perceived task significance). The consequences of perceived task significance are seen in other linkages of our model; specifically, FSEs' task significance works to mitigate FSEs' emotional exhaustion, which in turn helps improve their job satisfaction.

The results offer new insights into how employee CSR perceptions can help frontline workers who are struggling with verbal dysfunctional customer behavior. The findings suggest that working for a service firm that is perceived to be socially responsible can help FSEs cope with emotional fatigue that results from the job stress of regularly dealing with deviant customers. As the first study to explore this previously unexplored relationship, CSR can indeed play a pivotal preventive mechanism on weakening emotional exhaustion effects by helping FSEs better manage their perceptions of vocal dysfunctional customer conduct.

Extending the work of Bauman and Skitka (2012), our results also suggest that CSR can help fill an individual's need for meaningful work in a frontline service environment. Hence, FSEs tend to experience less emotional exhaustion when they perceive their work tasks as meaningful via the notion that their work is positively contributing to other people's lives. The results also shed new light on the role of FSEs' CSR perceptions on the relationship between perceived task significance and emotional exhaustion of FSEs.

With job satisfaction serving as the outcome of our model, we have successfully replicated and extended the work previously published by psychology and sociology scholars by demonstrating that both perceived task significance and emotional exhaustion are directly associated with job satisfaction. Hochschild's (1983) theoretical work on emotional labor supports the negative relationship we found between emotional exhaustion and job satisfaction. In dealing with FSEs' perceptions of dysfunctional customer demands, CSR can play an effective role in reducing the strain that undermines job satisfaction. By showing how CSR can directly influence the meaningfulness of a worker in a frontline service setting, scholars are better positioned to enhance the positive link between task significance perceptions and job satisfaction (Morgeson and Humphrey, 2006).

Managerial implications

This study extends extant research about FSE boundary spanning emotional labor, especially regarding how CSR can serve as a mechanism for supporting FSEs as a safeguard to voiced dysfunctional customer behaviors. While a few scholars (e.g. Raub and Blunschi, 2014) have begun to recognize that employees' awareness of CSR heightens task

significance of their work, this marks the first study to examine the impact of CSR on FSEs' perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior. Our results are particularly important to service managers who are charged with helping FSEs cope with verbal dysfunctional customer behavior. The major managerial implications of our findings suggest that CSR has two potential effects on emotional exhaustion. First, CSR has a preventive effect on workplace stress reduction, as FSEs' perceptions of CSR may help them to be less affected by the emotional labor from serving overly demanding customers. Second, CSR provides a needs fulfillment effect, as FSEs' perceptions of CSR foster perceived task significance, which in turn reduces emotional exhaustion.

This study also has managerial implications regarding the value of service firms for ensuring their employees' involvement with CSR initiatives and regularly communicating their CSR initiatives to their FSEs. Not only does CSR improve the public image of service firms but it helps with the level of FSE engagement by giving them a sense of they are part of an organization that actively contributes to "the greater good." The stronger the alignment between an organization's FSEs and the firm's particular CSR activities, the more likely that FSEs are to share their identification with the organization. CSR gives FSEs something to believe in and identify with on a deeper level instead of just as a place of employment. CSR can help FSEs feel less stressed when they find themselves having to defend their company's reputation to hostile customers.

Given the broad range of CSR initiatives companies may focus on, it is paramount to identify the social and environmental issues that are most important to their employees. In reality, most employees are not close to their employer's CSR efforts and therefore may only be vaguely aware about the specific CSR activities the company engages in (Sen *et al.*, 2006). At a minimum, companies need to inform their FSEs more fully about their good works. Preferably, companies should directly seek their participation in CSR activities. As an illustration of this point, a recent survey by Cone (2016) found that 78 percent of workers in the USA agreed that their job is more fulfilling when they are provided opportunities to make a positive impact on social and environmental issues. The results of our study further reveal that meaningful employee engagement around CSR can serve as a key factor toward enhancing the meaning of their work.

Limitations and directions for future research

The present study provides scholars and marketing managers with a better understanding of the process by which FSEs' perceptions of CSR impact emotional exhaustion and job satisfaction. However, this work should be evaluated in light of its limitations, which lead to future research opportunities. The hypothesized model was tested using field sample survey data drawn from a large South Korean insurance company. Future research should investigate the examined relationships of our model with subjects drawn from other service industry contexts to improve the generalizability of our results.

The field work nature of our study afforded less researcher control. Because the model's constructs were measured by using field survey self-report measures of respondents' perceptions, strong evidence of causal effects cannot be concluded unequivocally. We utilized a correlational design to examine the relationships among the five constructs of our model, which inherently leaves an unclear causality among the constructs. For example, with respect to service delivery, dissatisfied FSEs experiencing vocally dysfunctional customer behavior can become engaged in deviant behavior toward their customers (Van Jaarsveld *et al.*, 2010). Future research in manipulating the constructs in an experimental design setting and an analysis of the effects of manipulation would clarify these causality issues in our conceptual model.

This study investigates how FSEs' perceptions of CSR can enhance meaningful work perceptions as well as help alleviate their views of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior.

We see new opportunities for scholars to examine other potential CSR mediators and outcomes, using similar stress-strain-outcome models (Tetrick *et al.*, 2000). Creativity, for example—a key driver for service improvement could be considered as a factor in enhancing the FSEs' ability to manage dysfunctional customer behavior (Brammer *et al.*, 2015; Geng *et al.*, 2018). Another way to build upon our model is to expand on the psychological processes between FSEs' perceptions of CSR and dysfunctional customer behavior. It is hoped that scholars continue work on the potential relationships among employees' perceptions of CSR, perceived task significance and emotional exhaustion and its linkage to verbal dysfunctional customer behavior perceptions held by FSEs.

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Construct	Items	Source(s)
FSEs' CSR perceptions	My company is a socially responsible company My company is concerned with improving the well-being of society My company supports good causes My company behaves responsibly regarding the environment My company is committed to using a portion of its profits to help nonprofits My company gives back to the communities in which it does business My company integrates charitable contributions into its business activities	Wagner <i>et al.</i> (2009); Berens <i>et al.</i> (2005); Lichtenstein <i>et al.</i> (2004)
FSEs' perceptions of verbal dysfunctional customer behavior	Customers easily get angry at me even over minor matters Customers make insulting remarks to me Customers make exorbitant demands in their claim for compensation Customers do not understand that they have to comply with certain rules Customers insist on demands that are irrelevant to their insurance coverage	Karatepe <i>et al.</i> (2009a); McColl-Kennedy <i>et al.</i> (2009); Wang <i>et al.</i> (2011)
Perceived task significance	My job provides opportunities to substantially improve the welfare of customers A lot of customers can be positively affected by how well my job gets done My job enhances the welfare of customers The results of my work are likely to significantly affect the lives of other people The job itself is very significant and important in the broader scheme of things	Grant (2008); Morgeson and Humphrey (2006)
Emotional exhaustion	I feel emotionally drained from my work I feel used up at the end of the workday I feel fatigued when I get up in the morning and have to face another day on the job	Maslach and Jackson (1981)
Job satisfaction	Overall, I am quite satisfied with my job I like my job I like my job more than many employees of other companies	Homburg and Stock (2004)

Table AI.
Construct scale items

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